PRESS KIT · SEPTEMBER 2026



Fish Don't return()_

Program fish to explore the deepest trench on Earth.

Block programming
Exploration, mystery

By Loerting Games
Tyrol, Austria

Coming soon
Windows · macOS · Linux · Steam Deck

AT A GLANCE

A programming game in the Mariana Trench

In *Fish Don't Return* you buy a fish with coins, drop it into the sea and give it a program made of blocks. Once you press Run it acts alone, doing exactly what its program says as it works its way down the trench after coins and chests. A fish can be programmed to come back up, but most of them never do. Whatever they find is yours to keep: coins for the next fish, new blocks and new kinds of fish.

At the bottom lies a ship broken in two. She went down in 1966, far out over the deepest water on Earth, and her searchlight is still turning.



01 Drop a fish in

Buy a fish with coins and drop it into the sea by hand.



02 Program it

Drag blocks into its program, such as "swim forever" and "if I see coin", then press Run.



03 Open chests

Chests hold coins, new blocks and new kinds of fish, and they stay yours after the fish is lost.

FACT SHEET

DEVELOPER & PUBLISHER
Loerting Games

BASED IN
Tyrol, Austria

RELEASE
Coming soon

PLATFORMS
Windows · macOS · Linux · Steam Deck

PRICE
To be announced

GENRE
Programming · Exploration · Mystery

PLAYERS
Single-player, offline

CONTROLS
Mouse and keyboard

LANGUAGES
English

ENGINE
Godot 4

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WEBSITE
fishdontreturn.com

STEAM
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THE GAME

How a dive works

Once a fish is in the water, its program is all it has. It sees what is in front of it and nothing through rock, so when the program asks “do I see a coin?”, the answer depends on where the fish is and which way it faces. You decide when it turns, how long it waits and how deep it goes. While it swims you can pause the water or speed it up.

Near the surface the coins are laid out in shapes, and further down in trails that lead along the rock into side passages. Chests sit on ledges and at the ends of those passages, and the one a fish swims into might hold a block that lets your fish tell how deep they are, or a Hauler, a slow and heavy fish that can take a beating.

Anything worth coming back to can be marked, and while it is out of view the edge of the screen points to it.

Fish are lost all the time. A lost fish stays where it sank, and you can open it to read the program it was running and see where it went wrong.



PROGRAMMING

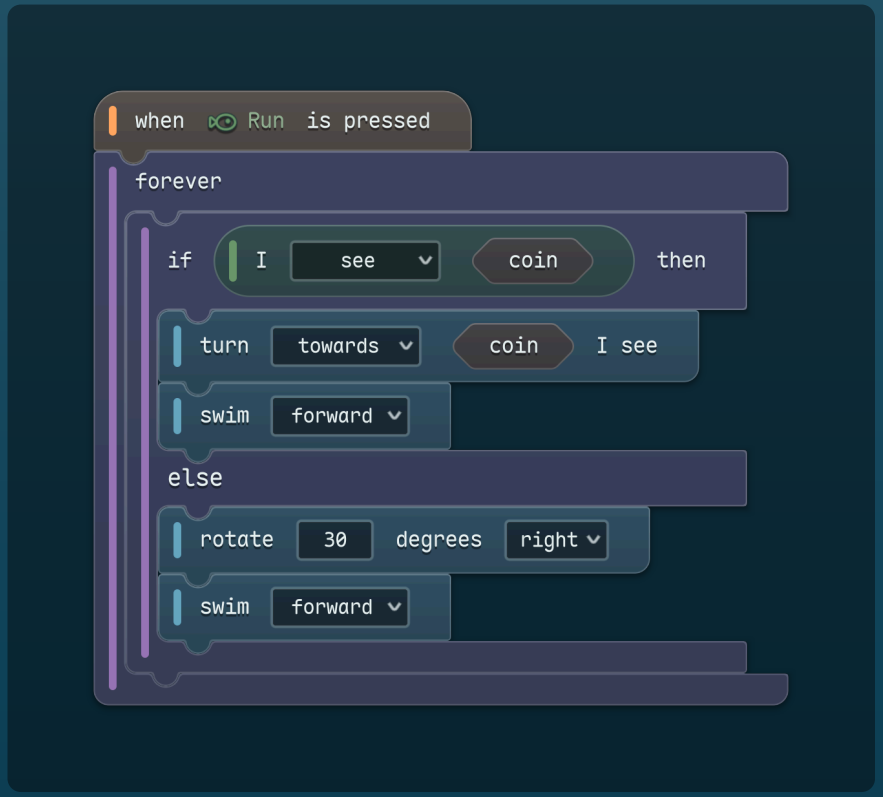
Programs you can read out loud

Fish Don't Return is the first programming game whose block programs read as plain English.

The program on the right is all a fish needs to start with: it turns until it spots a coin and then goes after it.

Blocks snap together, so there is no syntax to get wrong and nothing to memorise. That makes the game a good start for people who have never written a program, and for anyone who wants to learn.

Programs grow as the dive goes deeper. A fish can swim round a rock, wait until no hunter sees it, send a ripple that calls other fish to it, or swim back along its own trail when its health runs low. New blocks come from chests.



Pip's program, as the game draws it.



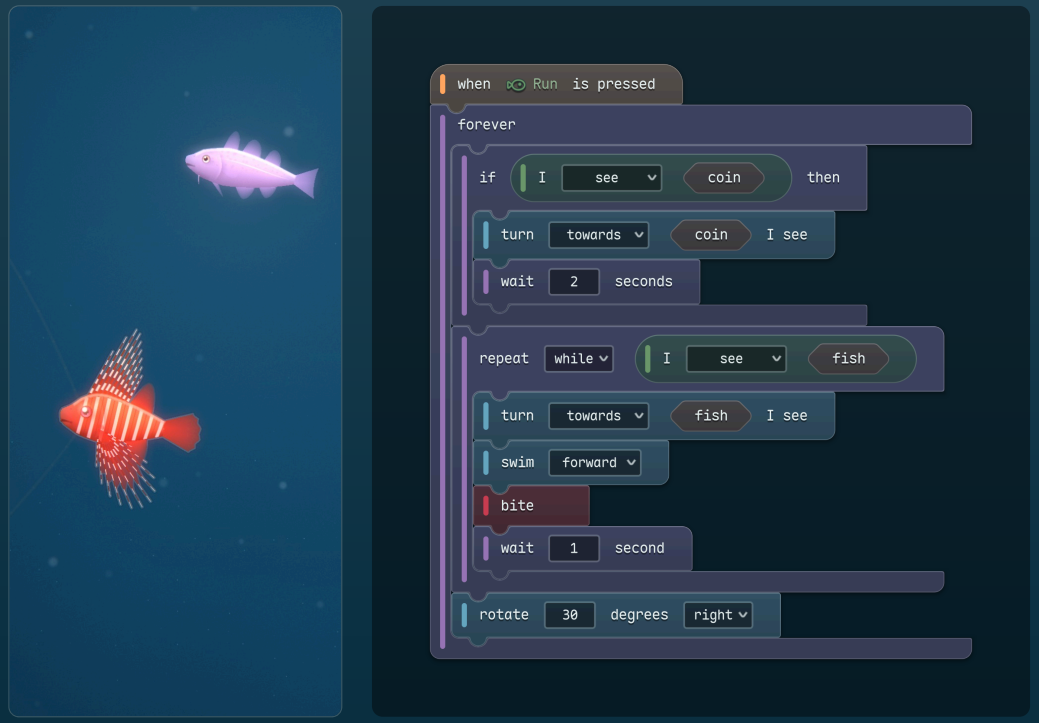
Hunters run programs too

The trench has its own hunters, and their behaviour is written in the same blocks your fish use. Click a hunter and open its program to read exactly what it will do, bites included.

The lionfish on the right stops to stare at any coin it sees for two seconds. Knowing that, you can write a fish that slips past behind it while it stares, or one that attacks it.

Some dangers stay put. Snappers grow out of the rock with a coin hanging in front of their jaws, clams blow bubbles that push fish into the rock, and vents erupt with scalding smoke. Their programs can be opened too.

Near the surface you can stop a fish and change its program as often as you like, so it is the place to try things out. Past the line at the top of the hole the water is dark, and there a program can only be changed inside the light of a violet crystal, so a plan has to work before the fish swims out of it.



A lionfish and its program, as the game opens it.

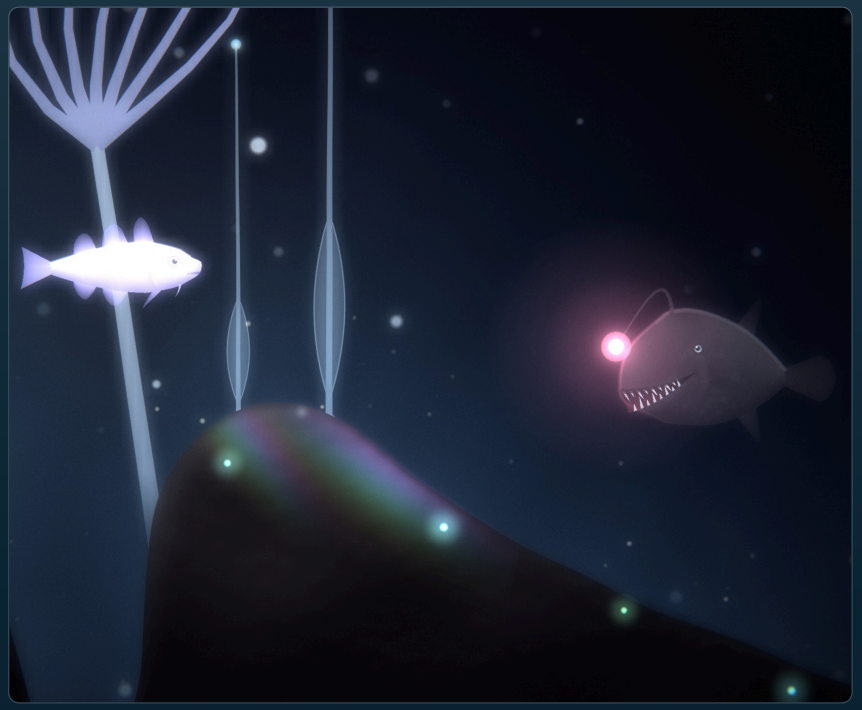


TWO OF THE HUNTERS



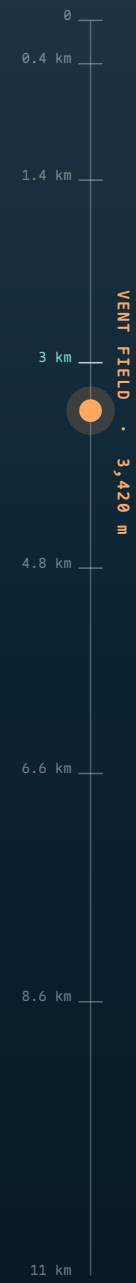
Marlin VENT FIELD

The marlin guards the Vent Field alone and charges faster than any fish you can buy. It winds up before each charge, raising its sail, and that moment is a fish's chance to turn away. After three charges it stops to rest for a few seconds.



Anglerfish GLASS GARDENS AND BELOW

The anglerfish never chases. It hangs in the dark with a light in front of its mouth and waits. A fish whose program says "swim towards the light", which is a good plan almost everywhere else in the trench, swims straight in.





Shelf 0 m
Sunlit sand and kelp over a flat basin.

Mouth 380 m
Dusk, where the basin gives way and the hole begins.

Narrows 1,400 m
Tight walls and standing stone, with silt falling off the ledges.

Vent Field 3,000 m
Smoking chimneys on black basalt.

Boneyard 4,800 m
A whale's bones, and a shark circling them.

Glass Gardens 6,600 m
Glass sponges, some with a light caught inside.

Hadal 8,600 m
The deepest water on Earth, down to the floor.

The Nadir

THE TRENCH

One hand-built trench, 11 km deep

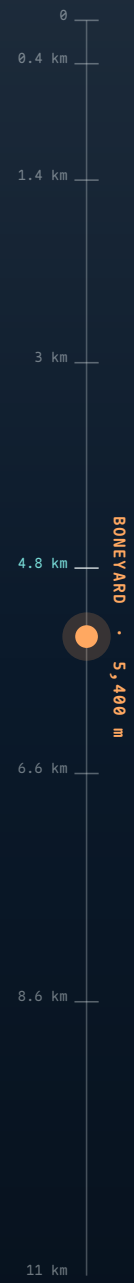
The map is a single cross-section of the Mariana Trench, built by hand and the same for every player. It gets darker the deeper you go: bright at the surface, dusk in the Mouth, and from the Narrows down the only light comes from your fish, the vents and the animals living there.

On the way down there is kelp that bends as fish swim through it, curtains of glowing hydroids that part around them in the Narrows, black smokers ringed with tube worms, and a whale skeleton under an arch of coins.

And there are things that don't belong on the seabed. An anchor lies in the sand at the top of the trench with its chain broken, and more pieces of a ship lie further down, all the way to the floor, where her searchlight still turns in the dark.



The first crystal in the dark, 780 m down. Inside its light a fish's program can be changed. Deeper down the crystals stay dark until a fish brings a light to them.



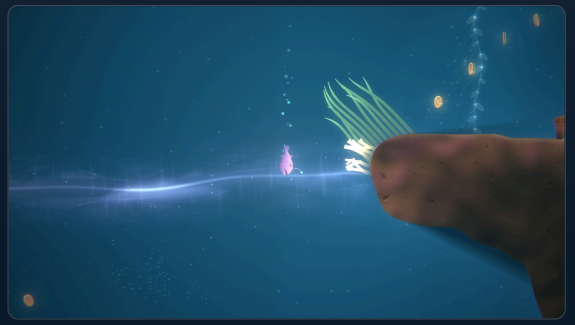
THE DEPTHS

Every region looks different

The trench changes on the way down. Each region has its own rock and its own animals, and the daylight is gone by the Narrows. Every picture on this page is a still from the game.



Shelf 0–380 m
A chest on the sunlit floor



Mouth 380–1,400 m
Where the daylight ends, across the hole



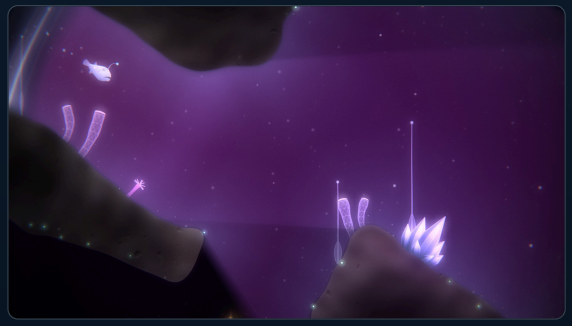
Narrows 1,400–3,000 m
Two Lanterns under glowing hydroids



Vent Field 3,000–4,800 m
A smoker erupting



Boneyard 4,800–6,600 m
The whale under its arch of coins



Glass Gardens 6,600–8,600 m
Glass sponges in a crystal's light



Hadal 8,600–11,000 m
An anglerfish beside a vent



WHY PLAY IT

What makes it different

Programming in plain English

Blocks snap together into sentences a newcomer can read, so there is no syntax to learn before the first dive. That makes the game suitable for children too.

Watch your fish explore

You write the plan, then watch a fish carry it out on its own, down caves and past hunters you have never seen.

Read the enemies

Hunters, snappers, clams and vents run programs you can open. Read one, find its weak spot and write a fish that uses it.

The wreck of the Nadir

A ship lies broken at the bottom of the trench. What is left of her lies along the way down, and each piece tells a little more of what happened.

Piano and string orchestra

Every region has its own piece, played on the piano by the developer and set for strings. Every coin a fish picks up sounds a note that fits the tune.

Lost fish tell you why

A lost fish lies where it sank with its program still inside, so a failed dive shows you what to change.

FISH TO BUY



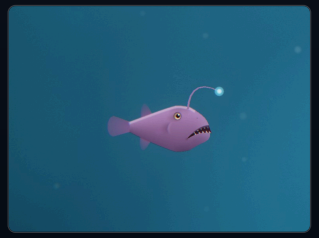
Minnow
Small and cheap. Slips through narrow gaps.



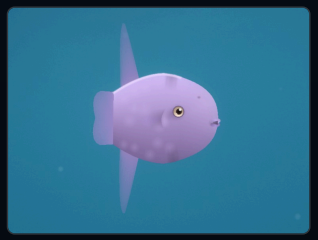
Scout
The all-rounder. Nothing special, nothing lacking.



Dart
The fastest thing in the water.



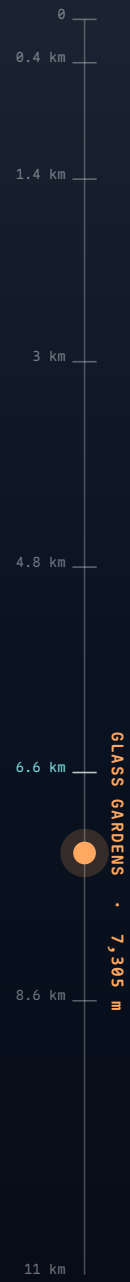
Lantern
Lights up the dark, but everything sees it coming.



Hauler
Slow and huge. Takes a beating and hits hard.



Thinker
Room for long programs. Thinks a little slower.



THE NADIR

What happened to the Nadir?

At the bottom of the trench lies a ship broken in two. She went down in 1966. Her searchlight still sweeps the dark, and when one of your fish comes near, the beam stops and stays on it.

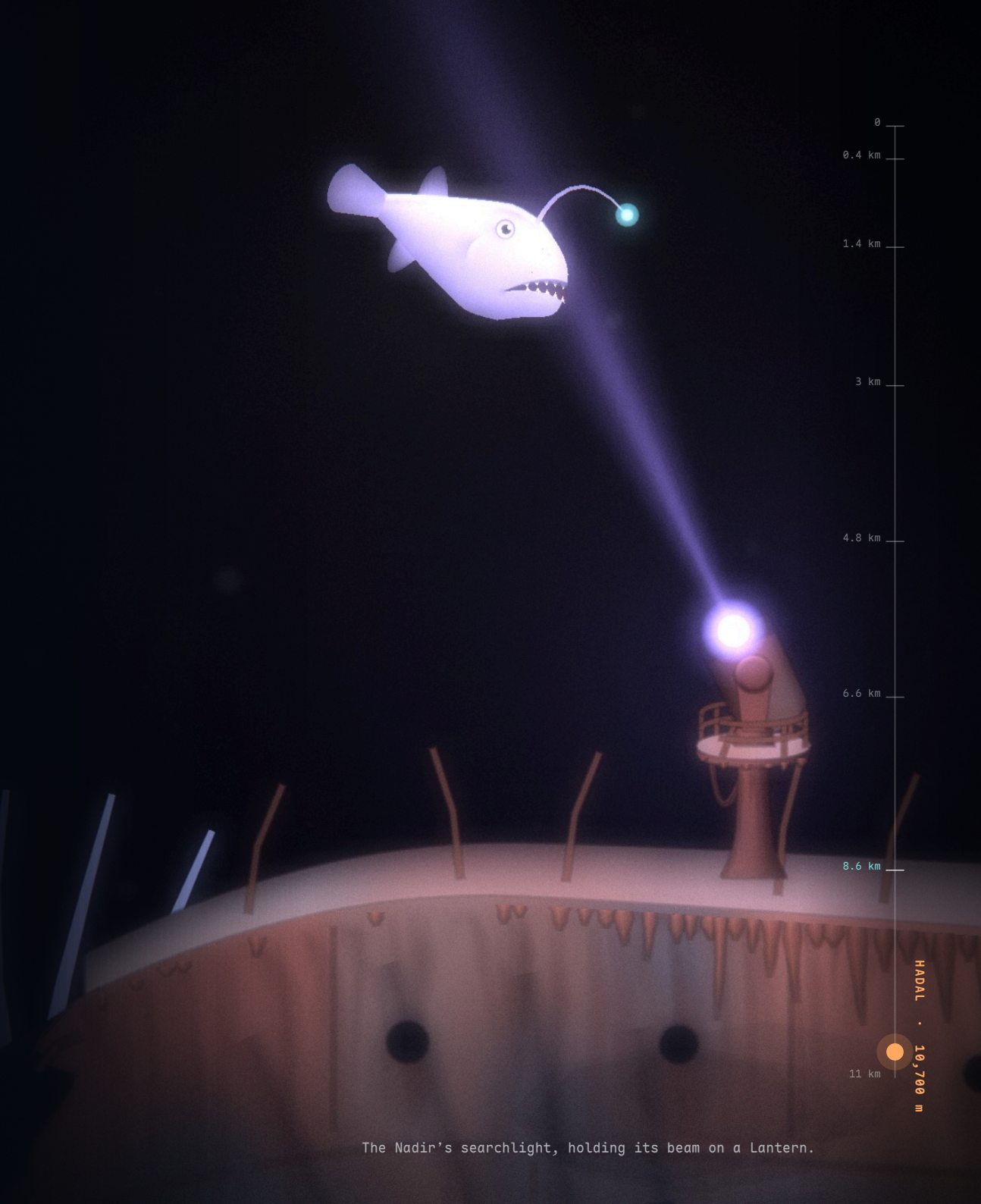
Twelve things from her lie along the way down, starting with an anchor at the top of the trench. Each has a line or two of text for the fish that reaches it, and read in order they tell her story. There is an ending for whoever gets that far.

> *Silk, still breathing in the current.*
> *Nothing is tied to the end of it.*

The parachute, 3.5 km down, as the game describes it.



The artefact menu. What your fish have not found yet is blacked out.



The Nadir's searchlight, holding its beam on a Lantern.

THE STUDIO

About the studio

Loerting Games is an independent game studio in Tyrol, Austria, founded by Leonhard Kohl-Lörting, who studied computer science at the University of Innsbruck.

The studio's first game, *Vena*, is an automation roguelike on a hex grid that won Godot Wild Jam #85 as a jam prototype. It comes out on Steam on 9 November 2026.

COVERAGE

You are welcome to stream, record and publish videos of *Fish Don't Return*, including monetised ones. Screenshots, logos and key art can be downloaded from the press page, and review builds are available on request.

CREDITS

DESIGN, CODE, ART, MUSIC	Leonhard Kohl-Lörting
ENGINE	Godot Engine (MIT licence)
TYPEFACES	Maple Mono and DINish (SIL OFL 1.1)
PALETTE	Ancient Heritage 30 by Sarahboev

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